

PROJECT REQUIREMENT DOCUMENT

Marketing AI

An Explainable, Compliance-Native Platform for Brand Reputation & Marketing Decisions

Working title — to be finalized

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1. Document Purpose

This document consolidates the product concept, market rationale, regulatory constraints, phased roadmap, and technical architecture for Marketing AI, an AI-assisted platform for brand reputation management and marketing compliance, launching first in the Indian market.

It is a working reference for the founding team, early engineering hires, and design-partner conversations — not a finished specification. Market figures and timelines are illustrative estimates drawn from desk research as of July 2026, and should be independently re-verified before use in investor or legal materials.

Reading guide: every major section is written to answer one of three questions — why this exists, when each part gets built, and how it works. Section 3 and 4 are the “why,” Section 8 is the “when,” and Sections 9–11 are the “how.”

2. Executive Summary

Marketing AI began as an idea to help new brands build social proof and reach quickly. Early scoping surfaced a critical fork: the fastest route to “impact” — synthetic engagement, fabricated reviews, and coordinated posting designed to shift public opinion — is both illegal in India and the US, and structurally fragile as a business, since it depends on staying ahead of well-funded, improving platform detection systems.

This document describes the legitimate alternative that was chosen instead: a platform built around genuine reputation monitoring, explainable AI-assisted decision-making, and — as its initial market wedge — automated compliance checking against India’s influencer and advertising disclosure rules. Enforcement data shows this specific area is currently underserved: no major competitor is primarily positioned around it.

The long-term vision is a dual-audience platform — a personal “PR co-pilot” for individuals, and an efficiency multiplier for marketing agencies — governed throughout by one non-negotiable design principle: no output reaches the public without a human-approvable, explainable rationale attached.

Go-to-market sequencing: agencies first, individuals second; a narrow, validated compliance MVP before the broader sentiment, ad-allocation, and agentive suite is built.

3. Background & Origin of the Idea

The founding premise: new brands struggle to earn trust and reach quickly — could an AI system replicate, or even outperform, what a PR team does. The initial framing included generating synthetic social proof (spam-style posts, manipulated reviews) to accelerate a shift in public opinion about a brand.

That framing was deliberately reworked before any build work began, for two reasons that are recorded here permanently as guardrails (see Section 6):

- **Legal exposure** — the US FTC’s Consumer Review Rule and India’s Consumer Protection Act / ASCI Guidelines both explicitly prohibit fabricated reviews and undisclosed brand-coordinated content, with active enforcement and real per-violation penalties in both jurisdictions.

- **Structural fragility** — platform detection of coordinated inauthentic behavior has improved faster than most manipulation techniques can evade it. A business model that depends on staying ahead of detection has a shrinking margin over time, not a growing one.

The reworked direction keeps everything genuinely valuable from the original idea — agentic AI, game-theoretic ad decisions, always-on monitoring, faster-than-human response drafting — while removing the fabricated, deceptive layer entirely.

4. Market Context — Why Now, and Why This Wedge

4.1 Global Landscape

Reputation and sentiment monitoring is a mature, well-funded global category, with established players including Brandwatch, Sprinklr, Meltwater, Talkwalker, Mention, Sprout Social, Reputation.com, Chatmeter, Birdeye, Brand24, and Revuze.

Agentic, autonomous ad-budget optimization is a newer but fast-growing category — Google Performance Max, Meta Advantage+, and Albert (by Zoomd) already manage bidding and budget allocation with limited human input. Industry research (McKinsey, April 2026) suggests agentic AI could power up to two-thirds of current marketing activities going forward, and the global AI marketing market was estimated at roughly \$47 billion in 2026.

Explainability is increasingly cited across enterprise agentic-marketing guidance as necessary for governance and trust in autonomous decisions — validating this platform's explainable-AI-first design choice rather than treating it as a nice-to-have.

4.2 India Landscape — Direct Competitors

Company	Focus	Relevance to Marketing AI
Locobuzz	India-headquartered unified CX / social listening / online reputation management; real-time sentiment alerts (~30 min detection); markets India data localization; serves BFSI and major Indian brands.	Closest direct competitor to the sentiment/listening half of the long-term vision.
Pixis	India-founded, ~\$30M raised; no-code AI infrastructure for marketing automation and ad performance optimization.	Closest direct competitor to the game-theoretic ad-allocation half of the long-term vision.

Implication: this is not a greenfield market. A head-on feature race against either incumbent, pre-funding, is not advisable — a narrower entry point is required.

4.3 Market Growth Signals

- India's influencer marketing sector is projected to reach approximately ₹3,375 crore in 2026, growing at roughly a 25% CAGR.

- India remains one of the fastest-adopting markets globally for AI-driven marketing tooling, across both agencies and in-house teams.

4.4 The Identified Wedge: Compliance

ASCI processed over 1,400 influencer-marketing violation cases through November 2025, with approximately 94% involving disclosure failures. Independent research separately found that a majority of India's top digital creators are not compliant with current disclosure guidelines.

No major competitor — global or India-based — is primarily positioned as a compliance-automation product for Indian advertising-disclosure law. This is the recommended market-entry point, detailed in Sections 8 and 9.

5. Regulatory Landscape (India) — Constraints the Product Must Design Around

5.1 Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 (DPDP) & 2025 Rules

- Establishes a consent-based regime for processing personal data.
- Scraping “publicly available” personal data sits in a contested gray zone: a statutory clause appears to exempt it, but the government has indicated in Parliament that consent is still expected. This should be treated as unresolved law, not a green light.
- Penalties can reach ₹250 crore per serious violation; obligations are phasing in through May 2027.

Design implication: default to official platform APIs (Instagram Graph API, YouTube Data API, etc.) wherever possible. Broad scraping is deferred to a later, legally-reviewed phase — not a default architecture choice (see Section 9.4 and Section 10).

5.2 ASCI Guidelines & Consumer Protection Act, 2019 (CCPA Enforcement)

- Mandatory “material connection” disclosure for paid or incentivized brand content; disclosure must be prominent, not buried in a hashtag block, and video content has specific placement/duration expectations.
- AI-generated or virtual influencers require an additional, explicit disclosure that the persona is not a real person.
- The CCPA can fine individuals up to ₹10 lakh and entities up to ₹50 lakh for misleading advertising or endorsement practices.
- IS 19000:2022 is India's own Bureau of Indian Standards benchmark for genuine, verifiable online reviews — conceptually parallel to the US FTC rule.

Design implication: this ruleset is specific, largely mechanical, and currently under-enforced due to a lack of tooling. It is the direct basis for the Phase 1 rule engine (Section 9).

5.3 Non-Negotiable Platform-Wide Constraints

These apply to every future version of the product, without exception:

- No fabricated reviews, followers, engagement, or synthetic “social proof” of any kind, under any framing.
- No undisclosed brand-coordinated content published on a client's behalf.
- Every public-facing output requires a human approval step before publishing — the “compliance gate.”
- Every automated flag or recommendation carries a stated, human-readable reason — the “explainability” requirement.

6. Target Users

Two segments, deliberately sequenced rather than launched together.

6.1 Segment A — Marketing Agencies (Go-to-Market Priority)

Buyer: agency owner or account manager.

Core need: manage more clients without proportional headcount growth; reduce compliance risk currently carried on clients' behalf; speed up review and response cycles.

Why first: agencies bring pre-existing client trust. A handful of agency design partners validates the product across dozens of end-brands at once, rather than convincing individual strangers one at a time.

6.2 Segment B — Individual “PR in Your Pocket” (Post-Validation)

Buyer: founder, executive, creator, or small business owner.

Core need: always-on monitoring of personal or brand mentions, draft-and-approve responses, early warning before a reputational issue escalates.

Positioning constraint: market as a co-pilot that escalates genuine judgment calls to a human — never as a full PR-team replacement. This is both the more honest claim and the safer one if a real crisis is ever mishandled.

Why second: benefits directly from case studies generated by Segment A; harder to sell cold, given that “people won't trust a new, unproven tool” was the founding problem statement.

7. Product Vision

Marketing AI is the explainable, compliance-native layer for brand reputation and marketing decisions — the system an agency or individual trusts precisely because it shows its work, not despite being new.

At full maturity, the platform combines continuous reputation monitoring, game-theoretic ad-budget optimization, and AI-assisted response drafting, all gated by a transparent, human-approvable compliance layer, serving both agencies (as an efficiency multiplier) and individuals (as a PR co-pilot).

8. Phased Roadmap — “When”

Durations below are illustrative planning estimates, not commitments, and should be re-scoped against actual team size and funding.

Phase	Focus	Est. Duration	Exit Criteria
Phase 1 — Concierge MVP	Manual/semi-automated ASCI + CCPA disclosure compliance checking for pilot agencies, via official APIs only.	Months 1–3	5–10 paying design partners; flag accuracy validated against expert judgment; explainability confirmed as a trust driver.
Phase 1.5 — Productized Tool	Automate the disclosure engine based on Phase 1 learnings; low-touch onboarding.	Months 4–6	Customers retained without concierge support; clear unit economics.
Phase 2 — Agency Suite	Add sentiment/listening engine, response-drafting agent, and initial game-theory ad-allocation agent. Agency-facing only.	Months 7–12	Agencies use the platform as a daily workflow tool, not an occasional check.
Phase 3 — Full Platform	Add data-science forecasting, optional graph-based influence analysis, full agent orchestrator; launch personal-PR product using Phase 2 case studies.	Year 2+	Personal-PR signups driven by agency case studies; platform-wide accuracy and trust metrics hit target.

9. Phase 1 (MVP) Requirements — “How,” In Detail

9.1 Assumptions the MVP Exists to Test

The MVP is scoped narrowly on purpose. Its job is to validate the following before any further build spend:

- Will agencies actually pay to fix disclosure compliance, or only acknowledge it as a problem in principle?
- Can violations be detected reliably enough, cheaply enough, to automate later?
- Does showing the reasoning behind a flag (explainability) measurably increase a skeptical buyer's trust?
- Does official-API-only data access cover enough real cases to be useful, without needing to scrape into DPDP's gray zone?

9.2 Functional Requirements

ID	Requirement
FR1	Ingest a brand's or influencer's public posts via official platform APIs (Instagram Graph API, YouTube Data API v3) for a defined account list.
FR2	Classify each post against ASCI/CCPA disclosure rules: presence, prominence, placement, and — for video — on-screen disclosure duration; flag virtual-influencer posts missing the secondary AI-disclosure requirement.
FR3	Attach a human-readable explanation to every flag, citing the specific rule it relates to.
FR4	Route flagged items to a human reviewer for confirmation before any report is delivered to the client.
FR5	Generate a per-campaign compliance report (flagged items, explanations, recommended fixes), exportable as a PDF or shareable link.

9.3 Non-Functional Requirements

- **Data residency:** store and process Indian user data on India-based infrastructure, aligned with prevailing data-localization expectations in this market.
- **Turnaround time:** compliance report delivered within an agreed SLA (e.g. 24–48 hours during the concierge phase).
- **Accuracy:** flag precision validated against manual, ASCI-standard review before any automation-accuracy claim is made externally.
- **Auditability:** every decision — flag or clearance — logged together with its explanation, for later review.

9.4 Explicitly Out of Scope for Phase 1

- Sentiment analysis / social listening engine.
- Ad-budget allocation / game-theory bidding agent.
- Full multi-agent orchestrator.
- Any data collection method beyond official APIs — no scraping.
- The personal-PR (Segment B) product.

10. System Architecture — “How,” Overall

10.1 Phase 1 Architecture

A deliberately narrow, five-stage pipeline:

- Data sources — official Instagram and YouTube APIs only.
- Disclosure rule engine — automated ASCI and CCPA compliance checks.
- Explainability layer — surfaces the specific rule and reasoning behind every flag.
- Human review — a reviewer confirms results before anything is delivered.
- Client output — a compliance report per campaign.

10.2 Target End-State Architecture (Phase 2–3)

Once the Phase 1 wedge is validated, the pipeline expands into the full vision:

- Data sources — official APIs, plus legally-reviewed scraping only where API coverage proves insufficient.
- Ingestion agents — scraping and API connectors feeding a shared data layer.
- Analytics & NLP engine — sentiment classification, forecasting, topic clustering, and optional graph-based influence analysis.
- Agent orchestrator — routes work to specialist agents: a listening agent, a game-theory ad-allocation agent, a response-drafting agent, and a creator-matching agent.

- Explainable compliance gate — human approval plus disclosure checks, now covering every agent's output, not only influencer posts.
- Client outputs — dashboards, reports, and approved actions, with a full audit trail.

The compliance gate is the one architectural element that should not change in character as the platform scales — every version, from Phase 1 through full maturity, routes public-facing output through an explainable, human-approvable step. This is the platform's core differentiator against Locobuzz and Pixis, neither of which is primarily positioned around compliance.

11. Technology Stack — “How,” Technical

Layer	Approach
Frontend	React-based dashboard; multi-tenant client switcher for agency accounts.
Backend / data	Node.js or Python API layer; PostgreSQL for relational data; object storage for generated reports.
Data ingestion	Official platform APIs (Instagram Graph API, YouTube Data API) in Phase 1–2; scraping layer deferred pending legal review.
Disclosure classification	Fine-tuned transformer classifier for disclosure detection, combined with rule-based checks for prominence, placement, and duration.
Sentiment & data science (Phase 2+)	Sentiment classification, topic clustering, time-series forecasting, anomaly detection for early issue warning.
Ad-allocation engine (Phase 2+)	Multi-armed bandit methods (e.g. Thompson sampling) for cross-channel budget allocation; auction-theoretic modeling for competitive bid scenarios.
Explainable AI	SHAP/LIME-style attribution for classifier decisions; a human-readable rationale layer wrapping every agent output.
Graph analysis (optional, Phase 3)	Network centrality (PageRank, betweenness) for influence mapping; community detection (e.g. Louvain) for sentiment-spread analysis.
Infrastructure	India-region cloud hosting for data residency; role-based access control for multi-client agency permissions.
Agentic orchestration	Task-routing framework coordinating specialist agents, with every output passing through the compliance gate before publication.

12. Compliance & Risk Framework

Risk	Description	Mitigation
Regulatory — scraping ambiguity	Broad scraping could create liability before DPDP case law is settled.	Default to API-only ingestion through Phase 2; commission legal review before any scraping expansion.

Risk	Description	Mitigation
Regulatory — rule drift	ASCI/CCPA disclosure rules can be updated or reinterpreted.	Maintain a versioned rule set; review quarterly against ASCI updates.
Competitive	Locobuzz and Pixis are funded incumbents in adjacent categories.	Win the compliance wedge first; avoid a feature-parity race pre-funding.
Trust & adoption	“New and unproven” was the founding problem statement.	Lead with explainability and concierge-phase case studies as the primary trust-building mechanism.
Model accuracy	False positives or negatives in disclosure classification erode trust quickly.	Keep a human reviewer in the loop through Phase 1–2; publish accuracy claims only after validation.

13. Success Metrics by Phase

- **Phase 1:** number of paying design partners; flag accuracy versus an expert baseline; qualitative signal that explainability is driving trust.
- **Phase 1.5:** customer retention without concierge support; gross margin per account.
- **Phase 2:** daily or weekly active usage by agencies; expansion revenue within existing accounts.
- **Phase 3:** personal-PR signups attributable to agency case studies; platform-wide accuracy and trust metrics.

14. Open Questions & Next Steps

- Finalize the working project name and brand identity.
- Identify and approach 5–10 candidate pilot agencies for Phase 1 design-partner conversations.
- Commission a focused legal review of the DPDP scraping question before any Phase 2+ scraping work begins.
- Decide the initial pricing model for Phase 1 concierge engagements.
- Validate India-region hosting and data-localization vendor options.

15. Sources Consulted (Desk Research, July 2026)

- Industry coverage of AI reputation-management and social-listening platforms, including Brandwatch, Sprinklr, Meltwater, Talkwalker, Mention, Sprout Social, Reputation.com, Chatmeter, Birdeye, Brand24, and Revuze.
- Coverage of agentic AI marketing platforms and McKinsey research on agentic AI adoption (April 2026).
- Publicly available company and product information for Locobuzz and Pixis.
- Reporting on India's DPDP Act 2023 and 2025 Rules, including parliamentary statements regarding the scraping of publicly available data.
- ASCI enforcement data and guidelines; Consumer Protection Act, 2019 / CCPA provisions; the IS 19000:2022 standard.

All figures above are drawn from public reporting as of mid-2026 and should be independently re-verified before use in fundraising, compliance, or legal materials.